

PROPOSAL · THE ECHELON V0 · WEBSITE &
MEMBER PORTAL

Intentionally simple. Built to grow.

The public website and the private Member Portal, designed on a phone first, launched together in ten weeks, for one fixed fee. Every question your document raises is answered here.

PREPARED
FOR

**Joe
Brocato**

IntenseGBD ·
The Echelon

PREPARED BY

Upperhand
Chicago

FIXED
FEE

\$24,000

LAUNCH

**Week
10**



A V0 as simple as you asked for.

Joe,

Thank you for the functionality document. It says what V0 does, what it leaves for later, and what you need from us before you decide.

This proposal builds the V0 you describe. Members sign in, browse Company Partners, read a profile and press Connect, and the public website launches alongside the portal. The questions your document raises are answered just below this letter.

Where your document leaves a decision open (the Progressive Web App, the native app, the W-9s) we give you our recommendation and the reason for it. And we build V0 so the things you set aside, the Ambassador dashboard, Partner logins and Shared Value, arrive later as new screens on the same foundation, without a rebuild.

One choice changes the price: how W-9s are handled. Section 05 shows how your two requirements fit together, and what each path costs.

John Williamson & Greg McDonald
Upperhand

THE SHORT VERSION

\$24,000

Fixed fee for V0, paid in three parts

10 weeks

From kickoff to launch

1 launch

Public website and Member Portal, together

\$45

A month for hosting, database and email, on accounts in your name

0

Plugins, templates or retainers

Yours

The custom code, the data, the design files and every account

What you asked, answered

01

THE BUILD COST

\$24,000, fixed, in three payments tied to milestones.

Investment →

02

RECURRING AND THIRD-PARTY COSTS

About **\$45** a month for hosting, database and email, with every other cost itemized.

Running costs →

03

TIMELINE AND MILESTONES

Ten weeks. Design approved in week 4, launch in week 10.

Timeline →

04

MOBILE-FIRST, CONFIRMED

Yes. Every screen is designed on a phone first, and fully responsive on tablet and desktop.

V0 →

05

A PROGRESSIVE WEB APP?

Yes, in V0. Members add it to their home screen. No app store.

Approach →

06

A NATIVE APP, LATER

Its own project, on the same foundation. Preliminary: **\$20,000 to \$35,000**.

Approach →

07

SECURE W-9S

Submitted through the portal, held by a specialist service. That meets both of your requirements.

W-9s →

08

SECURITY AND OWNERSHIP

Standard protection from the first build, and the work transfers to you: code, data, accounts.

Security →

Log in. Browse. Read. Connect.

"Members should be able to log in, browse Company Partners by ecosystem/category, view Company Partner profiles, and initiate contact with a Company Partner."

Your bottom line for the portal, September 21

WE BUILD VO SO THAT

- 01 A visitor can request Founding Membership on a phone in under a minute.
- 02 A Member gets from sign-in to a sent introduction in a few taps.
- 03 Every Connect is on record: the Member, the Company Partner, the date and the time.
- 04 Every Member carries their source, and their Ambassador where there is one, from the day they ask to join.
- 05 Your team makes routine changes without calling us.
- 06 Pages load in under 2 seconds on a phone with a typical 4G connection.
- 07 It looks like The Echelon, not like a template.

Everything on your list, launched together.

THE PUBLIC WEBSITE

HOME | THE ECHELON | EXPLORE | OUR STANDARDS | MEMBERSHIP |
SIGN IN

Home	The proposition in one scroll: trusted access, Member Benefits, the Member Advantage, the two ecosystems, and the invitation to request Founding Membership.
The Echelon	What it is, why it exists, how it works, and who Members, Company Partners and Ambassadors are.
Explore	The two ecosystems and their categories. Partner names stay inside the portal.
Our Standards	The six Standards, how Company Partners are selected (profile and questionnaire, diligence, background screening), what is expected of them, how one can be removed, and the disclaimer.

THE MEMBER PORTAL

PRIVATE • MEMBERS ONLY • INSTALLS TO THE HOME SCREEN

Home	An elegant welcome and three ways in: Explore, recent Partners, My Echelon.
Explore	Company Partners by ecosystem and category.
Profiles	One template your team fills in admin: logo, overview, why the Partner is relevant, services, differentiators, reach, website and contact, video, the Member Benefit, and the Echelon Member Advantage set apart at the top.
Connect	One button. It logs the request and sends the introduction email. More below.
My Echelon	The Member's details and every Partner they have asked to meet.

Membership

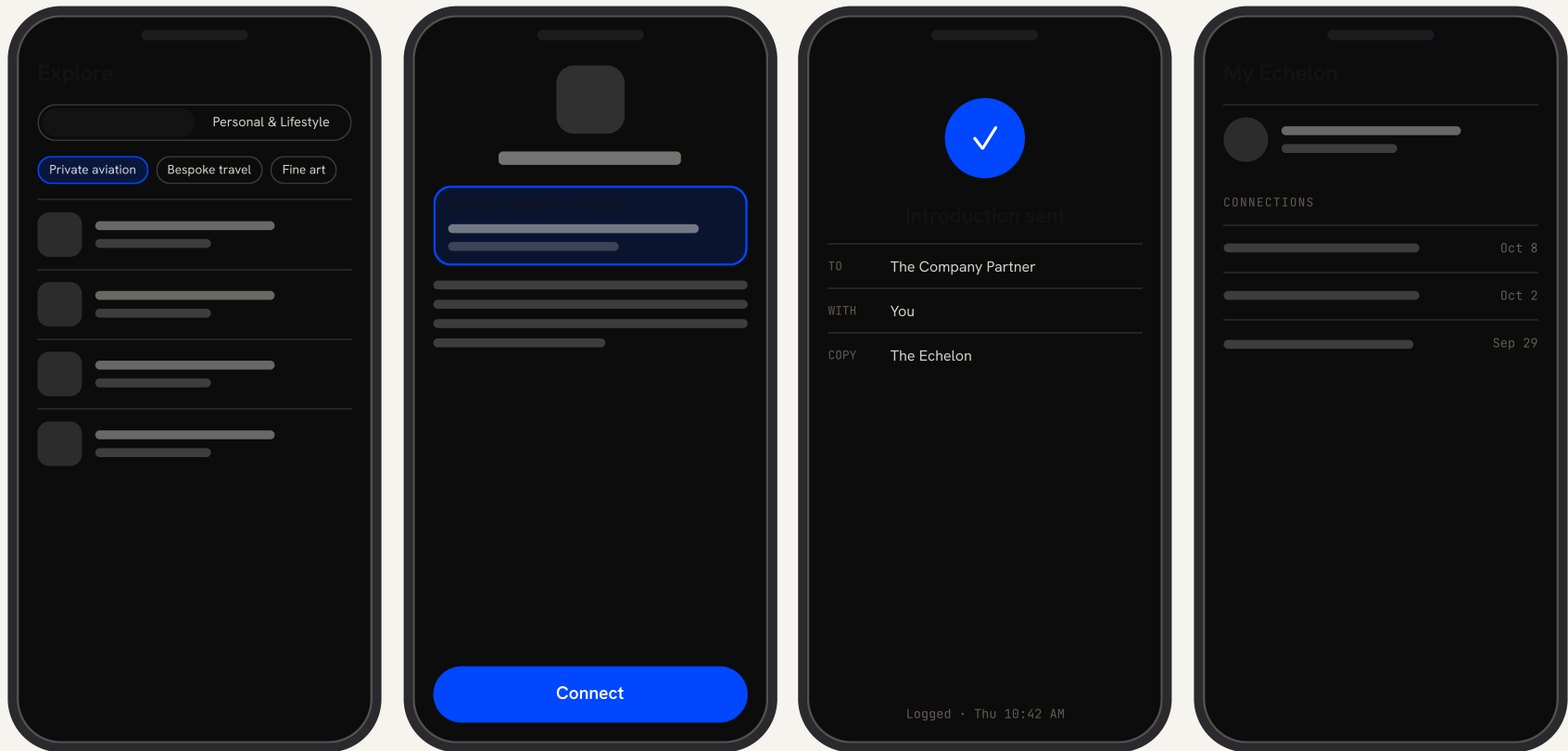
Who it is for, the benefits, Founding Membership, and a short request form. You approve each request; the approved Member completes enrollment, sets a password and accepts your Terms.

Sign In

Email and password, straight into the portal.
Footer: About, Contact, Privacy, Terms, Company Partner Disclaimer and the copyright notice.

Admin

Members, Partners, profiles, categories, Advantages, the membership queue, the connection report and a CSV export. Approved Members flow into Constant Contact.



1 · EXPLORE

2 · PROFILE

3 · CONNECT

4 · MY ECHELON

Wireframes, not the design. The look comes out of discovery and your brand standards.

When a Member presses Connect

01

The press is logged

Before any email goes out: the Member, the Company Partner, the date and the time.

02

One introduction goes out

From The Echelon, to the Partner, with the Member on the thread and IntenseGBD copied. Exactly the email you described.

03

They carry on by email

You are on the first message, so the introduction is in your records as well as the portal's.

04

It shows up twice

In the Member's My Echelon, and in your connection report, where it can be filtered and exported.

LEFT OUT OF V0, ON PURPOSE

~~Transaction and revenue tracking~~

Later, as Shared Value

~~An Ambassador portal or login~~

Later. The data is ready from day one

~~Partners editing their own profiles~~

Later, as Partner logins

~~Marketing automation~~

Constant Contact covers V0

~~Member social profiles and community~~

Not planned

~~Hosting our own video~~

YouTube embeds instead

Where you asked for advice, **our advice.**

Your list decides most of V0. These are the calls it leaves open, and what we would do with each.

01 Design it custom, build it on tested parts.

Your document rules out a site that looks off-the-shelf, and a site built from plugins usually does. Everything Members see is designed for The Echelon. Underneath, it is built from our own library of tested components on Next.js, Postgres and Vercel, which is most of why V0 costs what it does. The tools are standard, so another developer could take it over, and with no plugins there is far less to patch.

IN V0

03 Keep Connect on email, and log it at the button.

Email is where these conversations happen anyway, as your document says. The portal records the press before the email is sent, so the log is complete even when the conversation moves to email. Your team can mark each introduction as made, in conversation or closed. That records no dollar amounts, so V0 still tracks no revenue.

IN V0

02 Make the portal a Progressive Web App now.

Members add it to their home screen from the browser. It opens full screen with your icon and stays signed in. It costs nothing extra in V0, and it tells you how Members actually use a phone before you pay for an app.

IN V0

04 Give every Ambassador a personal link.

Anyone who requests membership through an Ambassador's link arrives with the Ambassador already recorded. For everyone else, the form asks how they heard of The Echelon. Your team confirms the answer at approval, and any later change is logged.

IN V0

05 Store Ambassadors and Partners as real records now.

Each Ambassador is a record of its own, linked to the Members they introduced. The Ambassador dashboard is then a new screen on existing data, which is how V0 meets your “without requiring substantial rework”. Partners get the same treatment, so Partner logins can follow the same way.

IN V0

07 Launch Explore with no empty shelves.

An empty category reads as a missing one. In the portal, a category appears once it has a live Partner. The public Explore page can still show every category you plan to fill.

YOUR CALL

06 Shape the profile around your questionnaire.

Your review process starts with a Company Partner Profile and questionnaire. We shape the profile template around it, so your team copies across only the answers meant for Members, in the same order Partners gave them.

IN V0

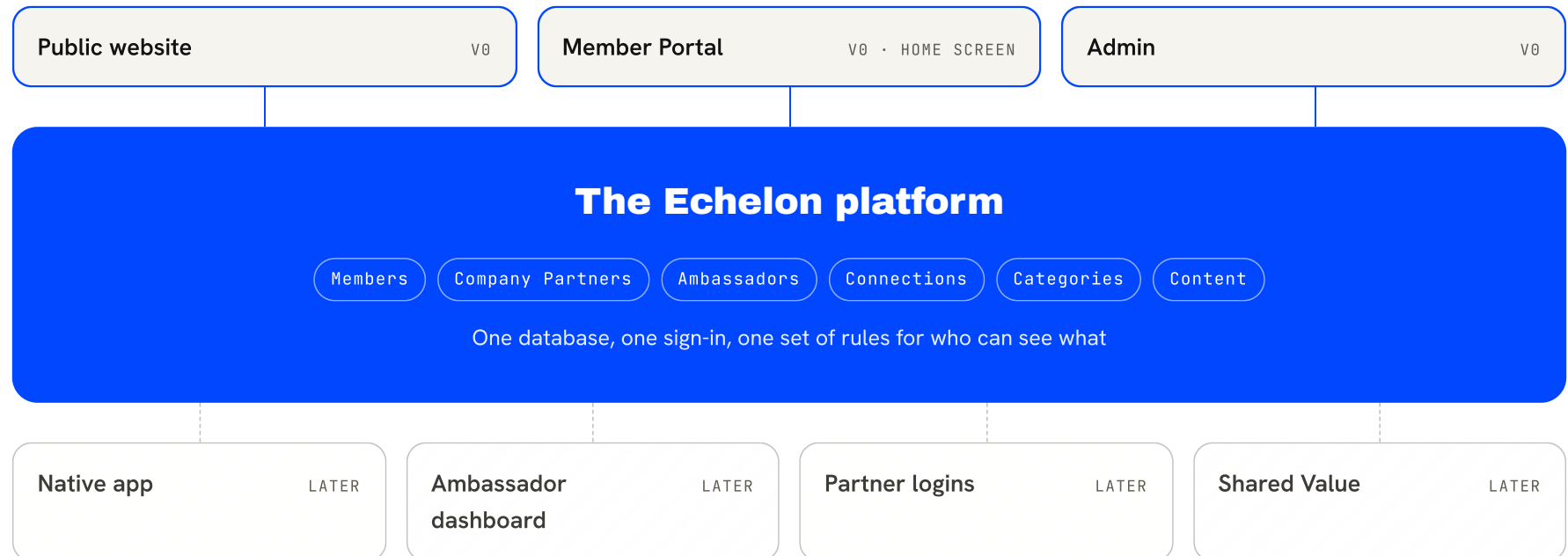
08 The fine print stays on your side of the table.

Terms, Privacy and the Company Partner Disclaimer are legal documents, so the words come from you. We set them into the site and ask Members to accept them at enrollment, with the time recorded.

YOUR CALL

One platform underneath all of it

Everything sits on one platform. What you add later, you add at the edges.



A web app now, a native app if use calls for it

Launch the portal as a Progressive Web App. Watch how Members use it for three to six months. If you then want a store listing, or you are adding features a browser can't handle, build the native app on the same foundation. The database, sign-in, admin and every rule carry over. The app's screens, notifications and store listings are the new work.

NATIVE IOS AND ANDROID APP • PRELIMINARY

\$20,000 to \$35,000

8 to 12 weeks, both platforms from one codebase. Plus Apple's developer program at \$99 a year and Google Play's \$25 one-time fee. We would quote it properly once V0 is in use.

	WEB APP, V0	NATIVE APP
WHAT EACH ONE GETS YOU		
Icon on the home screen	Yes	Yes
Opens full screen, stays signed in	Yes	Yes
iPhone and Android	Yes	Yes
Updates reach everyone	Instantly	After store review
Listed in the App Store and Google Play	No	Yes
Push notifications	Not in V0, possible later	Yes
Cost	Included	\$20,000 to \$35,000

Submitted through the portal, **held somewhere built for it.**

"We do not intend to store W-9s, Social Security numbers or other sensitive tax information in the V0 portal."

Your document, under Security and Privacy

Both can be true at once. Members submit their W-9 through the portal, and a specialist service holds it. That is Path A, and it is what we recommend. If you would rather keep the forms on your own platform, Path B is a build of its own.

"We expect to collect completed Forms W-9 from Members and Echelon Ambassadors and would prefer ... that they be securely submitted through the Platform."

Your document, under Secure W-9 Collection and Storage

PATH A · OUR RECOMMENDATION

A specialist service holds the forms.

Members open the W-9 from My Echelon. Ambassadors, who have no login in V0, get a secure link by email. Either way the form is completed with a tax-form service built for exactly this, and the portal stores only the status and a reference.

- ✓ Encryption, access control and audits are the service's specialty
- ✓ Many such services also offer tax ID matching and 1099 filing, if you need them
- ✓ Admin shows each record as requested, received or verified

\$1,000

to connect it, inside the ten weeks, plus the service's own per-form fees

PATH B

We build secure storage into the platform.

The forms live with us, in storage kept apart from everything else, and only designated IntenseGBD administrators can open them.

- ✓ Encrypted in transit and at rest, in segregated storage
- ✓ Two-factor sign-in, and every view and download written to an audit log
- ✓ Backups, plus a retention and deletion schedule you set

\$4,000

as its own build after V0, or two more weeks if it runs alongside. Holding tax forms means keeping that storage secure for as long as you keep them.

Either way: no W-9 is ever an ordinary upload, and the admin record shows its status without exposing a single number from the form.

Protected from the first build, and yours at handover.

Standard, well-tested measures for a members-only site, and a clean handover of everything we make for you.

HOW V0 IS PROTECTED

- ✓ Encrypted in transit on every page, and encrypted at rest in the database
- ✓ Members see only their own record and their own history, enforced by the database, not just the screen
- ✓ Administrators sign in with two-factor authentication
- ✓ Every admin change is logged: who, what and when
- ✓ Daily backups kept for seven days, and a CSV export of your records whenever you want one
- ✓ Rate limits and spam protection on sign-in and every form
- ✓ No Social Security numbers or tax information stored in the portal. Path B, if you later choose it, adds its own protections

WHAT YOU OWN

- ✓ The website, the portal, the database and all custom code, transferred to IntenseGBD on final payment
- ✓ The design files, the content, and all Member and Company Partner data
- ✓ Every account, opened in IntenseGBD's name from the first week. We work as invited collaborators
- ✓ Our underlying component library stays ours, with a perpetual, royalty-free license to you, so nothing you own depends on us
- ✓ A written handover, so another host or developer can take it over

ACCOUNTS IN YOUR NAME

Domain

Vercel

Supabase

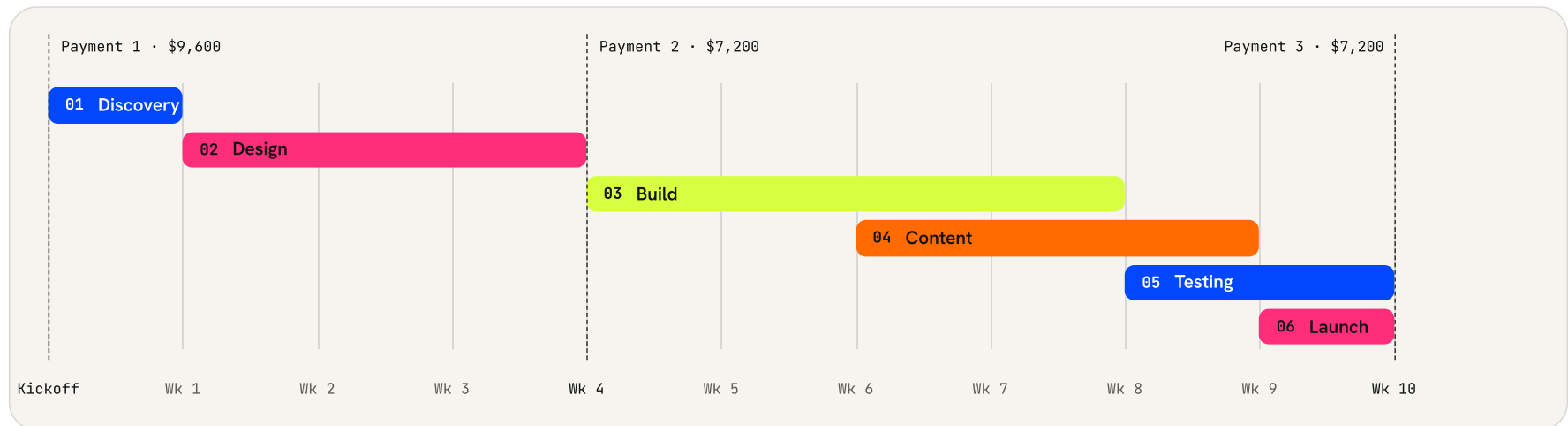
Resend

Constant Contact

GitHub

Ten weeks from kickoff.

Every milestone your document names is here: design approval, development, testing, content population, user acceptance testing and launch. Design approval and launch each trigger a payment. The dates assume reviews come back within two business days; if one takes longer, launch moves by the same number of days.



01 Discovery & planning

Week 1

A working session on the Member journey, a look at your questionnaire, and the decisions that shape the build: roles, the profile template, the Connect email.

YOU GET

the sitemap, the data model and a signed-off plan

WE NEED

two hours with you, your brand standards and the questionnaire

02 Design

Weeks 1 to 4

Your brand carried into a digital system, then every page and screen, phone first. One design direction, a clickable prototype of the portal, one round of revisions and a final polish.

YOU GET

the approved design, milestone 1

WE NEED

one decision-maker for the reviews

03 Development

Weeks 4 to 8

The website, the portal, admin, Connect, Constant Contact and security, built in that order. You get a private preview link on the first day of the phase, and it changes every week.

YOU GET

a working preview to click through each week

WE NEED

the Constant Contact account and the final text of the legal pages

04 Content population

Weeks 6 to 9

We load the first three Company Partners with your team, then you carry on in admin. Page copy goes in, videos get embedded.

YOU GET

admin training while it matters

WE NEED

the launch Partners' profile information and logos

05 Testing & user acceptance

Weeks 8 to 10

We test on iPhone, Android and desktop. Then your team, and a few Founding Members if you want, use it for real and send us everything they find.

YOU GET

a fix list, closed before launch

WE NEED

your sign-off that it is ready

06 Launch

Week 10

The site replaces "Launching Soon" at theechelonsignature.com and the portal opens to approved Members. For thirty days after, we fix anything that does not work as scoped.

YOU GET

V0, live, milestone 2

WE NEED

your first invitations ready to send

One fixed fee for V0.

\$24,000

Fixed, for the line items below and everything marked In V0 in sections 03 to 07. If the scope holds, the price holds. If you add something, we price it in writing before we start it.

It stays lean for three reasons: we build on our own component library, we work to one design direction, and your team loads most of the Partner profiles.

This price holds through October 31, 2026.

THREE PAYMENTS

40%

At signing

Before kickoff

\$9,600

30%

Milestone 1: design approved

Week 4

\$7,200

30%

Milestone 2: launch

Week 10

\$7,200

If launch waits on content or sign-off from your side, the final payment falls due ten business days after user acceptance testing begins.

LINE	ITEM	FIXED
01	Discovery & planning - A working session with you on the Member journey, from the request form to the first Connect - The Company Partner profile template, shaped around your Company Partner Profile questionnaire - Sitemap, roles and the Connect email, signed off before design starts	\$1,500
02	Brand extension & design - Your logo and brand standards carried into a digital system: type, color, spacing - Every public page and portal screen, designed on a phone first, then on a desktop - One design direction, one round of revisions and a final polish pass - Vector versions of the logo, redrawn if they do not exist yet	\$5,500
03	Public website - Home, The Echelon, Explore, Our Standards, Membership and Sign In, plus the footer pages - The Request Founding Membership form, with the source and Ambassador captured on the way in - Search basics, social previews, video embeds, and pages for your Terms, Privacy and Company Partner Disclaimer	\$3,500
04	Member Portal - Password sign-in, the Member home, Explore by ecosystem and category, and Company Partner profiles - Profiles with logo, overview, services, reach, contact, the Member Benefit and a prominent Echelon Member Advantage - Connect: the email introduction, logged at the button with the Member, the Partner, the date and the time - My Echelon, with account details and connection history - Installs to the home screen on iPhone and Android, as a Progressive Web App	\$6,500
05	Administration - Add, edit and remove Members, Company Partners, profiles, categories, Member Advantages and page content - The membership queue: approve a request and send the enrollment link; the Member sets a password and accepts your Terms - The connection report, a CSV export of Members, Partners and connections, and the source and Ambassador on every Member record	\$3,000
06	Integrations & security - Constant Contact: approved Members added to your list automatically - Email for Connect introductions, sign-in links and approvals, sent from your domain - Two-factor sign-in for administrators, an audit log of admin changes, daily backups, rate limits on every form	\$2,000
07	Testing & launch - The first three Company Partner profiles loaded with you, then your team carries on - Testing on iPhone, Android and desktop, then user acceptance testing with your team - Launch, an hour of admin training, a written guide, and thirty days of fixes for anything that does not work as scoped	\$2,000
Total, fixed fee		\$24,000

What it costs to run

Everything outside our fee, as you asked: hosting, plugins, forms, email, security, backups, maintenance and Constant Contact. Checked against each vendor's published prices on September 25.

WHAT	NOTE	MONTHLY
Hosting and security certificates Vercel Pro	Includes SSL, a global network, DDoS mitigation and a web firewall. Includes one developer seat, which is enough; more are \$20 each	\$20
Database, sign-in, file storage and daily backups Supabase Pro	Backups kept for 7 days	\$25
Connect introductions and sign-in email Resend	Free to 3,000 emails a month (100 a day), then \$20	\$0
Forms and plugins Built in	Nothing to license	\$0
Member email Constant Contact	Your plan, priced by list size. Connecting it adds nothing	Yours today
Domain theechelonsignature.com	You already own it; the renewal stays yours	Yours today
At launch		\$45

AT LAUNCH

\$45 a month

ONLY IF YOU NEED IT

More than 3,000 emails a month +\$20 a month

Restore to any minute, not just the last daily backup +\$100 a month

App store accounts, \$99 a year + \$25 once once there is an app

MAINTENANCE

No retainer. After the thirty days of fixes, you buy hours when you need them. A Path A W-9 service charges its own fee per form.

Small additions, priced now

W-9s, through a specialist service **RECOMMENDED**

Our recommendation. We connect the service and show each Member's W-9 status in admin. The service's own fees are separate.

\$1,000

one time

Block of hours

Ten hours for changes, new pages and updates after the thirty days of fixes. Prepaid, used as needed, no retainer.

\$1,500

per 10-hour block

Bigger builds, each its own project

W-9s, stored in the platform

Encrypted, segregated storage with administrator-only access, two-factor sign-in, an audit log and a retention schedule.

\$4,000

one time

Native iOS and Android app

Preliminary, on the same foundation as V0. We would quote it properly after a few months of real use.

\$20,000 to \$35,000

preliminary

Ambassador dashboard, Partner logins, Shared Value tracking

Each one scoped and quoted on its own, when you are ready for it. V0 keeps the records they build on: Ambassadors, Partners and every connection.

Quoted

one at a time

About Upperhand 🖐️

Upperhand is a studio in Chicago, led by John Williamson and Greg McDonald. We've spent decades starting, running and selling companies, and building the brands and products inside them.

Both of us work on The Echelon with you from kickoff to launch, supported internally by our dedicated team. We've hired agencies ourselves, which is why this proposal has a fixed fee, an end date, and accounts in your name.



What happens next

01

Walk through it

Reply to John with a time next week. Thirty minutes with both of us, on the scope, the recommendations and your questions.

02

Settle the W-9s

Path A, Path B, or not in V0. Whichever it is, the final number follows the same day.

03

Sign

A short services agreement by e-signature, with this scope attached as written.

04

Kick off

Within five business days of the first payment. Ten weeks from kickoff, V0 is live.

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Prepared for Joe Brocato, IntenseGBD, LLC • The Echelon, September 25, 2026. Confidential. Running costs are each vendor's published price on September 25, 2026, and may change. The Echelon name and logo belong to IntenseGBD, LLC.

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